

**IN CONTEXT**

## GENRE

**Neo-noir crime thriller**

## DIRECTOR

**Roman Polanski**

## WRITER

**Robert Towne**

## STARS

**Jack Nicholson, Faye Dunaway, John Huston**

## BEFORE

**1941** John Huston's movie noir *The Maltese Falcon* is released, and Polanski studies it avidly before he embarks on making *Chinatown*.

**1968** *Rosemary's Baby* is Polanski's acclaimed horror movie about a young woman, played by Mia Farrow, who is impregnated by the devil.

## AFTER

**1988** *Frantic*, starring Harrison Ford, is Polanski's first successful return to the thriller genre since making *Chinatown*.

**R**oman Polanski's movie *Chinatown* is a gripping thriller with a truly nasty sting in its tail. Jack Nicholson plays the seedy private detective Jake Gittes, who investigates a conspiracy surrounding the Los Angeles water supply in the 1930s. During the course of his investigation, he uncovers a disturbing personal tragedy as he becomes involved with the chief water engineer's wife, Evelyn Mulwray, played by Faye Dunaway.

**Powerful script**

Key to the movie's power is Robert Towne's Oscar-winning script, which is widely regarded as one of the finest screenplays ever written for Hollywood. It was partly inspired by the true story of William Mulholland, chief engineer of the Los Angeles Water Department, who, on March 12, 1928, declared that the St. Francis Dam was safe, just hours before it failed catastrophically, with the resulting flood killing at least 600 people. In Towne's screenplay, Mulholland

“Time has lessened our sense that this superlative 1974 film is simply a pastiche of the classic '30s gumshoe thrillers—it now looks like a straightforward classic.

**Peter Bradshaw**  
*The Guardian*, 2013

becomes Hollis Mulwray, and the story turns into a fictional tale of the corrupt manipulation of the Los Angeles water supply for profit.

Towne wrote the script with Jack Nicholson in mind for the character of Gittes, the private eye who becomes unwittingly embroiled in the shadowy affairs of Mulwray's associates. Nicholson is said to have been responsible for

“**He owns the police!**”

**Evelyn Mulwray / Chinatown**

**Jack Nicholson Actor**

Jack Nicholson is one of the leading American movie actors of the last half century, renowned for playing difficult outsiders who can disarm with charm and humor. He was born in 1937 in Neptune City, New Jersey, where he grew up. His Hollywood acting career was slow to take off, and he had more success with writing screenplays. He had his first big acting break in Dennis Hopper's *Easy Rider* (1969), and a year later, his performance in *Five Easy*

*Pieces* (1970) was widely acclaimed. Both movies brought him Oscar nominations for his acting, while *One Flew Over the Cuckoo's Nest* (1975) earned him his first Oscar win.

**Key movies**

**1970** *Five Easy Pieces*  
**1974** *Chinatown*  
**1975** *One Flew Over the Cuckoo's Nest*  
**1980** *The Shining*